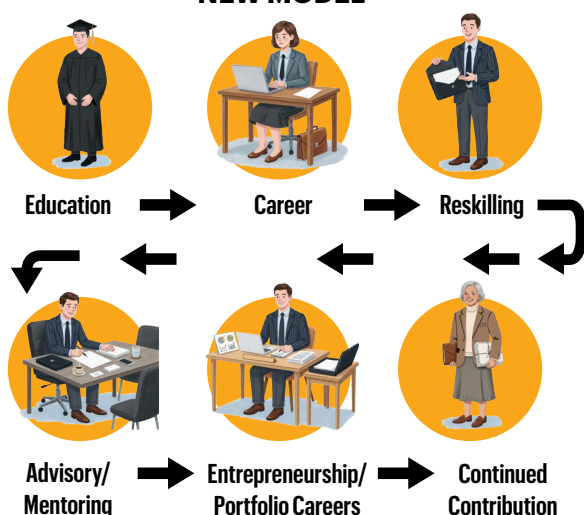


HOW CAREERS ARE CHANGING

OLD MODEL



NEW MODEL



What Older Employees Need

- Better retirement and financial planning
- Support for caregiving responsibilities
- Continuous digital and AI upskilling
- Greater focus on physical, mental, and cognitive wellbeing

Where Organisations Are Falling Behind

Many companies still rely on:

- Traditional performance, promotion systems
- Linear career paths
- Fixed retirement norms
- Succession models that undervalue experienced talent

transformation, governance, advisory and fractional CXO roles, where judgement and leadership matter as much as technical expertise.

“As AI changes the way businesses work, companies are realising technology alone isn’t enough,” Sharma says. “They also need people with sound judgement, leadership experience and ability to manage change. That’s why many forward-looking organisations now see experienced professionals as a strategic advantage rather than a cost.”

EXPERIENCE IS IN DEMAND

While organisations increasingly value experienced professionals, demand varies widely across sectors, says Sonal Bahl, Partner at global executive search and leadership hiring firm Positive Moves. She points out that private equity-backed firms actively seek seasoned CEOs and board members who have navigated multiple business cycles, transformations and periods of uncertainty.

The picture is different in consumer technology and new-age start-ups. “Companies such as Zomato, Swiggy, and Flipkart have built leadership teams around younger founders and executives who closely mirror the customer base they serve,” she says. Even FMCG firms are increasingly handing digital businesses to younger leaders with contemporary consumer insights and digital-first capabilities.

Even as boards value experience and judgement in an AI-driven world, Bahl believes those qualities are often difficult to assess in hiring processes that remain focused on measurable KPIs and short-term outcomes.

“Judgement and resilience are prized in principle, but they are hard to quantify in a hiring process built around measurable KPIs and short-term impact metrics. Often, these intangible strengths lose out to tangible, recent and quantifiable wins.”

Age bias today is rarely explicit, she says, but often appears as concerns around “energy” or “pace” that never make it onto a formal scorecard.

Many leadership mandates are widening age brackets because resilience, sound judgement and pattern recognition built over multiple business cycles are increasingly scarce among younger candidates.

THE BUSINESS CASE FOR EXPERIENCE

For organisations grappling with AI, the challenge is no longer choosing between younger digital talent and experienced professionals. Increasingly, business leaders argue that competitive advantage will come from combining both.